A King Like the Nations

1 Samuel 8 · 1 Samuel 15–17 · 1 Samuel 24

The big idea: Israel demanded a king like all the nations and got Saul, who looked the part and would not obey. God chose a shepherd boy by looking on his heart, and David defeated Goliath as Israel's champion, in the name of the LORD.

Before you meet: Read

1 Samuel 8:4–22 | 1 Samuel 16:1–13 | 1 Samuel 17:32–51

Open (5 minutes)

When you were growing up, who did you want to be like? Why?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Now appoint for us a king to judge us like all the _____." *(1 Samuel 8:5)*

"Behold, to _____ is better than sacrifice, and to listen than the fat of rams." *(1 Samuel 15:22)*

"Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the _____." *(1 Samuel 16:7)*

"For the battle is the _____, and he will give you into our hand." *(1 Samuel 17:47)*

Discuss

1. Israel wanted a king like all the nations. Why was that a rejection of God? Where are you tempted to want to be like everyone else? *1 Samuel 8:5–7, 19–20*

2. Saul looked like a king, and David looked like a shepherd boy. What does 1 Samuel 16:7 say about how God chooses and how we judge? *1 Samuel 16:6–13*

3. How does it change the Goliath story to see yourself as one of the frightened soldiers rather than as David? *1 Samuel 17:8–11, 51–52*

4. David twice refused to kill Saul when he had the chance. What does it look like to wait for God's timing instead of grabbing what he has promised? *1 Samuel 24:1–7*

Memory verse

"For the LORD sees not as man sees: man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart."

1 Samuel 16:7

Pray

Confess the ways you have wanted a king like the nations. Ask God for eyes to see as he sees, and thank him for the King he chose.

LEADER NOTES · WEEK 27

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Session plan (about 45 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read 1 Samuel 16:1–13 and 17:40–51 aloud together.
5 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
20 min	Discuss: choose three of the questions.
5 min	Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (2 Samuel 7, 11, and 12, and Psalm 51).

Main points to land

1. Israel's demand for a king like the nations was a rejection of God as their King (1 Samuel 8:7).
2. Saul looked impressive but would not obey. God chose David by looking on the heart (1 Samuel 15:22–23; 16:7).
3. David fought Goliath as Israel's representative champion, a picture of the Son of David who wins the victory his people cannot (1 Samuel 17:8–9, 47; Hebrews 2:14–15).

Answer key (Observe)

1. nations
2. obey
3. heart
4. LORD's

Questions people will ask

If God wanted Israel to have a king one day, why was asking for one wrong?

God had planned for a king (Deuteronomy 17:14–20), but Israel asked for the wrong reason: to be like the nations, with a king who would fight for them in place of trusting God (1 Samuel 8:5–7, 19–20). The problem was not kingship. It was a heart that wanted security without God.

Closing prayer

Father, you see not as man sees. Forgive us for wanting a king like the nations, and for judging by appearances. Thank you for David, and thank you far more for Jesus, the King nobody expected, who fought the battle we could not win. Amen.